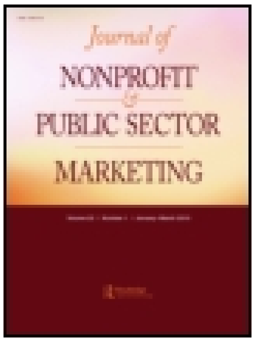

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The Impact of Familiarity and Perceived Trustworthiness and Influence on Donations to Nonprofits: An Unaided Recall Study

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ABSTRACT

What affects donations? Is it all in "the ask," or does brand image matter? In the nonprofit brands literature perceived trustworthiness and influence of the organization are important factors that increase constituents' willingness to support an organization. We examined the association between a nonprofit organization's familiarity, trustworthiness, and influence and the propensity of donations it receives. To this end, we used a questionnaire on attitudes toward nonprofit organizations and unaided recall of nonprofit organizations collected from a nationally representative sample. The attitudes data revealed that perceptions of nonprofits' effectiveness and trustworthiness in Israel are not particularly positive. A multivariate fractional polynomial regression on the unaided recall results shows that while familiarity and perceived effectiveness are positively associated with the propensity of donations to nonprofit organizations, trustworthiness is not. We explain this surprising result by changes in Israeli social policy, political culture, and trust in institutions. We suggest different efforts that organizations can make to enhance their brand image and consequently increase donations.

KEYWORDS

Nonprofit brands; donations; unaided recall; trustworthiness; effectiveness

There is extensive literature on the variables that affect donor decision-making. It lists diverse influences such as crowding out and crowding out effects (e.g., Brooks, 2000), amount of money requested (Weyant & Smith, 1987), familiarity with the recipient (Lesner & Rasmussen, 2014; Small & Simonsohn, 2006), donor values and social standing (Wiepking, 2008), and even the location of the donor on the soliciting organizations' mailing lists (Meer & Rosen, 2011). Recently Bekkers and Wiepking organized and categorized the many possible causes for and influences on charitable donations (Bekkers & Wiepking, 2010, 2011; Wiepking & Bekkers, 2012). Others developed theoretical models, which try to explain the complete donor decision-making process (Sargeant, 1999; Schervish & Havens, 1997). The goals of this article are much more modest. It aims to examine how familiarity with an organization and the perceived

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influence and perceived trustworthiness of that organization affect the probability that an individual will donate to the organization.

A prime factor predicting donations is being asked to give (Andreoni, 2006; Andreoni & Payne, 2003; Bekkers & Wiepking, 2010; Meer & Rosen, 2011). Yörük (2009) tested this so-called power-of-asking assumption (p. 1111) and found that donation requests increase the likelihood of giving by almost one-fifth. The effect was robust under different specifications and with different sets of instruments. Thus, it might be that in many cases it doesn't matter what the organization does, how it does what it does, or how well it does it. What matters is that the organization approaches potential donors, albeit, in an age of increased accountability expectations (Ebrahim, 2016) and extensive competition between nonprofit organizations on the donor's "dollar," when donors are flooded with multiple solicitations (Bekkers & Wiepking, 2010), such a conclusion is less than desirable.

The public image of nonprofit organizations is an important factor affecting their ability to solicit donations. This is at the heart of the discourse on nonprofit brands. Applying Aaker's brand personality dimensions (Aaker, 1997) to the nonprofit world, Venable, Rose, and Gilbert (2003) came up with a five-factor structure of nonprofit brand personality that included four of the five dimensions identified by Aaker (excitement, competence, sophistication, and ruggedness), and suggested a fifth factor—nurturing. In a later study, Venable, Rose, Bush, and Gilbert (2005) suggested four somewhat different dimensions of brand personality for nonprofits: Integrity, Nurturance, Sophistication, and Ruggedness. In a different inventory, Bennett and Gabriel (2000) listed emotive altruism, efficiency, trust, and modernity. Voeth and Herbst (2008) suggested a three-way model, with the factors social competence and trust, emotion and assertiveness, and sophistication. Michel and Rieunier (2012) developed a scale of nonprofit brands with four dimensions: usefulness, efficiency, affect and dynamism. Finally, Sargeant, Ford, and Hudson (2008) listed emotional engagement, service, voice, and tradition. They found that these traits are useful both for differentiation between different nonprofit organizations and for predicting facets of individual giving behavior. A closer inspection of the different models reveals repeating facets. The two of interest to us here are trust (Bennett & Gabriel, 2000; Voeth & Herbst, 2008), which is sometimes defined as confidence or integrity (Venable et al., 2005), and influence, which appears in the different models under different guises such as competence (Venable et al., 2003), efficiency (Bennett & Gabriel, 2000; Michel & Rieunier, 2012), or usefulness (Michel & Rieunier, 2012).

Trust is important for the existence and success of charity organizations. According to Tonkiss and Passey (1999) and Sargeant and Lee (2002), trust is the foundation of charity and voluntary organizations. Donating money to a charity organization requires trust because information asymmetries make it impossible for donors to estimate the quality of the service provided

(Greiling, 2007). According to Bekkers (2003), even a single report about opportunism can easily damage the reputation of the whole charity sector and, in particular, the reputation of the specific organization in question. Tonkiss and Passey (1999) argue that nonprofit organizations relations with stakeholders are in fact governed by confidence, and that confidence is dependent on formalized arrangements rather than more generalized trust. In a series of surveys on public perceptions of charities, Light (2008) found that public views of charitable organizations in the United States are unfavorable. Only 16% of Americans said in 2008 that charitable organizations do a very good job running their programs and services. The respect expressed toward nonprofit organizations declined steadily, including with regard to specific evaluations such as financial prudence, effectiveness and fairness. In a study of donors in Chile, Torres-Moraga, Vásquez-Parraga, and Barra (2010) found three factors that have a direct effect on donor trust. While an organization's reputation and familiarity with the sector improve donor trust, perceived opportunism lowers it. The authors also noted that the communication effectiveness of the soliciting organization and donor's familiarity with the sector both influence the organization's reputation. Sloan (2009) analyzed accountability ratings of New York charities by the Better Business Bureau's Wise Giving Alliance. Her study showed that accountability ratings have a complex relationship with donations: Whereas "pass" ratings increase donations, "did not pass" ratings had no significant effect.

Perceived influence—namely, the belief that the organization achieves its goals, is a key criterion in the donor's decision-making process (Sargeant, 1999). When testing their scale of nonprofit brands, Michel and Rieunier (2012) found efficiency to be the strongest predictor of monetary donations. In a study of British donors, Breeze (2013) noted that donors desire to have a personal impact. Accordingly, she found that donors' perception of the organization's competence, particularly its financial efficiency, is an important determinant of donations. A survey on a large sample of donors (Sargeant, Ford, & West, 2006; Sargeant, West, & Ford, 2004; Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2005) showed that performance of the organization (defined as "This nonprofit is the nonprofit most likely to have an impact on this cause") increased trust, which increased commitment to the organization, resulting in more donations. Elsewhere, Sargeant and Lee (2002) found that "role competence" (define as "understanding of the needs of the beneficiaries, changes therein and the best way to resolve these issues," p. 79) is a significant predictor of giving behavior. An Internet survey among Dutch donors found that donors consider the effectiveness of the organization to be important, although it is not the main criterion in the selection of a charity to donate to (Van Iwaarden, Van Der Wiele, Williams, & Moxham, 2009). Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) listed efficacy among their eight mechanisms that drive charitable donations and define it as the perception of donors that their contribution makes a difference to the cause they are supporting. They reviewed a multitude of studies that showed that when people perceive that their contribution will not make a difference, they are less likely to give. In addition to that, they reported experimental studies that showed that when donors have information about the effectiveness of their contributions it increases their donations. For example, Parsons (2007) ran a field-based experiment with a real nonprofit organization and found evidence that the likelihood of repeating donations increases when donors received financial efficiency information on the organization.

The question addressed here is whether all that is required to secure a donation is for the organization to ask or to be known to the potential donor. The nonprofit brands literature indicates that the image of the organization also matters and, particularly, the perceived influence and trustworthiness of the organization. Thus, this article examines the following hypothesis: Both familiarity with an organization, the perceived influence, and the perceived trustworthiness of that organization affect the probability of an individual donating to the organization.

As the study was performed in Israel, it is beneficial to elaborate a little on the Israeli context. In Israel, a consistent process of welfare state retrenchment evolved into what Mizrahi calls alternative provision of public services (Mizrahi, 2012). Therefore, a significant growth in "gray market" services provided mostly by nonprofit organizations accompanied the cutback in public social and human services in Israel since the 1980s. As a result, there has been tremendous growth of the third sector in Israel, predominantly in human and social services, funded predominantly by the state (Gidron, Bar, & Katz, 2004). In the 1990s, it became clear that only initiatives of this kind could help many groups of people obtain the services needed (Mizrahi, Vigoda-Gadot, & Cohen, 2009). During this time, popular perceptions continued to favor state-provided services. Political-attitudes studies show that Israelis prefer state intervention in the supply of public services, support public investment in services related to the welfare state, and assert the state's obligation to support those in need (Cohen, Mizrahi, & Yuval, 2011). At the same time, these studies have shown a steady decline in the confidence of Israelis in institutions. Thus, a significant gap is growing between social and economic policies and the attitudes of large parts of Israeli society toward the welfare state. Furthermore, various charity scandals, growing criticism over executive compensation, and political criticism over legitimacy of nonprofits and their funding sources have become prominent. In addition to that, Mizrahi et al. (2009) showed that in Israel, perceived performance is the main predictor of client trust and participation in health and human services.

Methods

We performed the study in collaboration with the Israeli nonprofit rating agency Midot. It used an online questionnaire, developed by the author and the Midot analysts' team, and distributed the questionnaire to a nationally representative sample, through the panels surveying firm's Internet panel Panel4all. Data collection was performed pro bono by Panels LTD. Respondents were guaranteed anonymity, following informed consent, and were rewarded for participation in the form of accruing small credit for future monetary rewards.

The questionnaire consisted of four parts. The first part contained a series of eight questions collecting perceptions of nonprofit organizations, such as level of professionalism, proper management, corruption, service quality and more, and questions on donation habits. In the second part, we asked the respondents to list as many nonprofits as they could (unaided recall) that the respondents were familiar with that they thought were trustworthy, that they thought were influential, and to which they had donated. Unaided recall is an accepted method for collecting data on brand awareness (Aaker, 1996; Agarwal & Rao, 1996; Chandon, 2003). In the third part, we showed the respondents a list of nonprofits and asked the respondents to mark the nonprofits they were familiar with (aided recall). Finally, in the fourth part we collected some basic sociodemographic data.

The sample was representative of the general Israeli adult population (18+), and used a layered sample by age and place of residence (N = 566). Maximal sampling error was ±4.1%. The composition of the sample by age, gender, nationality, household income, educational attainment, and region was found to be similar to national distributions of the same variables. The sample patterns of donations (frequency and monetary value) were also similar to those found in a national study (Haski-Leventhal, Yogev-Keren, & Katz, 2012).

For the purpose of this paper, we analyzed parts one and two of the questionnaire. We organized the responses in two files. One had a list of respondents, a respondent per row, and his or her answers to part one questions in the columns. The second had a list of all the nonprofits named by respondents in the unaided recall section of the questionnaire, one organization per row. For each nonprofit in that list we calculated the proportion of respondents who mentioned a nonprofit firm in response to the four unaided recall questions: familiar, trustworthy, influential, and donated.

Thus, in this study the dependent and independent variables were proportions, defined as a fraction and observed only within the bounds of the range $0 \le y \le 1$. It is common in economic and management research, which may include variables such as participation rates, market share, proportion of debt, and so on (Ramalho, Ramalho, & Murteira, 2011). The bounded nature of proportion data and the chance that a substantial part of the distribution may accumulate at one or both boundaries make standard linear models unsuitable. Since the mid 1990s researchers began to advance fractional regression models and procedure that take into account the specific characteristics of fractional response variables (Papke & Wooldridge, 1996; Ramalho et al., 2011). These models are specifically tailored to fit proportional or fractional dependent variables. The program used here was STATA MFP procedure—Multivariable Fractional Polynomial (Royston & Ambler, 1998, 1999). This procedure fits an optimal prediction model through a search for suitable fractional polynomial transformations for continuous predictors (Sauerbrei, Meier-Hirmer, Benner, & Royston, 2006). Fractional polynomial functions do not assume that the outcome variable and the predictors relate to each other in a linear fashion. While often this is a fair description of the relationship, in other cases, different models may offer better fit. Instead of fitting a single linear model ($y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \ldots$), fractional models fit a variety of power transformation models ($y = \beta 0 + \beta_1 X_1^{P1} + \beta_2 X_2^{P2} + \ldots$), chosen from a restricted set. Royston and Altman (1994) suggested the following set: $\{-2, -1, -0.5, 0, 0.5, 1, 2, 3\}$, where X_0 denotes $\log(X)$. To fit the model, the procedure assesses each of the eight values of p and selects the model with the highest likelihood. Nonlinearity is tested through a significance test of $p = 1$ against $p \neq 1$. In a multivariate model, the aim is to include in the final model only variables with influence on the outcome. The process involves three main steps: (1) a test of inclusion for each predictor, (2) a test of nonlinearity of effect for each predictor, and (3) a test of simplicity of power transformation required for each predictor (Baneshi, Nakhaee, & Law, 2013). The best transformation for each predictor is selected using backward elimination through an adaptive algorithm. Depending on the p values associated with the best transformations, the procedure may exclude one or more predictors from the final model.

Findings

The perceptions of nonprofits professionalism and propriety are not extremely positive: only about half or fewer of the respondents consider nonprofits as professional, providing good services, and treating donor money properly (see Table 1).

When asked to freely recall nonprofits (unaided recall), respondents recalled on average eight nonprofits (median was seven nonprofits). Only 5.5% recalled none, and one respondent recalled no less than 45 organizations. In all, respondents named 576 nonprofits. The most recalled nonprofit was the Israel Cancer Society, with 87% recall. Recall rates drop rapidly, and only 10% of the sample recalled at least 14 organizations. Figure 1 shows the distribution of nonprofits recalled for each of the four unaided recall questions. While obviously more organizations were familiar than they were trusted, reputed as influential or received donations, all

Table 1. Perceptions of Nonprofits' Professionalism and Propriety.

	Percentage of respondents who agree
Nonprofits promote the public interest.	63.7%
Nonprofits provide quality service.	50.4%
Nonprofits use donor money properly.	47.0%
Nonprofits are managed professionally.	39.4%
I can trust that my donation reaches its goal.	39.1%
Nonprofits promote private interests.	37.8%
Nonprofits are corrupt.	29.0%
Nonprofits are amateurish.	21.9%

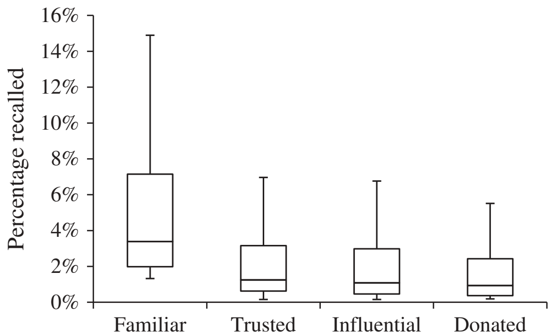

Figure 1. Unaided recall of nonprofits.

four variables seem to concentrate closer to the bottom boundary and have a relatively long upward tail.

Next, we fitted a multivariable fractional polynomial model to the data. The independent variable in the fractional polynomial regression was proportion of donors to a specific nonprofit, and independent variables were the proportions of those reporting that the organization was familiar, perceiving the organization as trustworthy, and perceiving it as influential. Despite the skewed distributions of the four variables, the procedure did not find the three independent variables' relationship with the dependent variable to defy linearity. Consequently, all three independent variables were entered into the model. Table 2 shows the results of the multivariable fractional polynomial model.

Table 2. Results of the Multivariable Fractional Polynomial Model.

Number of observations						95
LR chi^2(3)						98.03
Prob > chi^2						0.000
Log likelihood						−145.407
Pseudo R^2						0.252
Donated	Coefficient	Std. Error	z	$p > \|z\|$	[95% confidence interval]	
Familiar	0.545	0.134	4.07	0.000	0.282	0.807
Trustworthy	−10.165	17.382	−0.58	0.559	−44.233	23.904
Influential	49.609	18.737	2.65	0.008	12.884	86.333

The model is significant and it explains over 25% of the variance in the proportion of donations. The coefficients' table shows that both the proportion of persons familiar with a nonprofit organization and the proportion of persons that consider it to be an influential organization predict the proportion of persons donating to the organization. Both variables, *Familiar* and *Influential*, have a positive relationship with *donations*: as familiarity and perceived influence of a nonprofit increase, so increases the likelihood of donations to that organization. Perceived influence was a stronger predictor than familiarity. The proportion of persons considering the organizations as trustworthy is not a significant predictor of the proportion of donations.

Discussion

The "power of asking" assumption (Yörük, 2009) is a truism in fundraising, arguing that being asked to give and consequently knowing of the requesting organization is the prime factor predicting donations (Andreoni, 2006; Andreoni & Payne, 2003; Bekkers & Wiepking, 2010; Meer & Rosen, 2011), albeit the literature on nonprofit brands argues that brand personality—namely, the perceptions of the organization by potential constituents—affects their willingness to support the organization (Bennett & Gabriel, 2000; Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Sargeant et al., 2008; Venable et al., 2005, 2003; Voeth & Herbst, 2008). Two factors that feature prominently in this literature are confidence and perceived influence. This study tested the extent to which familiarity of a nonprofit and how often it is perceived as trustworthy and influential affect the propensity of donations it receives. We collected unaided recall of nonprofit organizations from a nationally representative sample in Israel. The data revealed that on the whole, similar to what was found in the United Kingdom and the United States (Light, 2008; Saxton, 2004), the perceptions of nonprofits' professionalism and propriety in Israel aren't particularly positive, although they are markedly more positive than what was reported in the United States (Light, 2005, 2008). The unaided recall data revealed that while familiarity and perceived effectiveness are positively associated with the propensity of donations to nonprofit organizations, trustworthiness is not. This finding is surprising, especially since trust is a foundational element of charity and voluntary organizations (Tonkiss & Passey, 1999; Sargeant & Lee, 2004) and a major factor affecting donations (Sloan, 2009; Torres-Moraga et al., 2010). Economic theory of nonprofit organizations places great emphasis on trust, as a remedy to inherent information asymmetries typical of services that nonprofit organizations provide (Greiling, 2007; Ortmann & Schlesinger, 1997; Young, 2015). Yet, trust in nonprofit organizations in developed nations seems to be considerably low and even decreasing in some places (Light, 2005, 2008; Saxton, 2004).

How can we explain this contradiction? Is it that in a cynical society—wherein one presumes automatically that all are self-serving, inefficient, and corrupt—the public image of an organization as clean and trustworthy is irrelevant? What is the reasoning behind this cynical view of nonprofit conduct? Is it perhaps that moral expectations are so low and social needs are so high that as long as the organization does some good, it is seen as "better than nothing at all"? In the Israeli context, such a notion may not be surprising. It presumably has to do more with political culture and institutional trust than with particular trust in specific actors in the system. This disinterest in trustworthiness is a result of the declining confidence in institutions in Israel in recent decades. This distrust is coupled with the consistent process of welfare state retrenchment, despite popular perceptions that favor state-provided services (Cohen et al., 2011). The result is an emergence of a culture of self-reliance in the provision of social services that leads to a preference of performance as the main criterion of trust and participation in services (Mizrahi et al., 2009). It is plausible that this gap between political preferences and actual policies, and the frustration that it engenders, plus the bend toward performance nurture a laissez-faire attitude toward the services that nonprofit organizations provide. To be able to prove or disprove this explanation, we need more research of two types. Firstly, we need research that repeats the current one but in a broad interculturally comparative context. Such research can examine how differences in political culture, in welfare state policies, and in generalized trust and confidence in institutions affect the dynamics that we found. Secondly, we need research that looks at how individuals make donation choices under different conditions of trustworthiness, familiarity, and influence and under different contexts accounting for levels of trust and levels of public social provision, preferably in a controlled experimental design.

What do our findings imply for fundraising organizations? We found that trustworthiness does not predict donations. Yet, this is likely due to the specific Israeli context in which we conducted the study. Therefore, we urge organizations to enhance and communicate their brand personality to potential donors. Transparency is a strong signal for trustworthiness and effectiveness. A current website, with easily accessible data on programs, finances, officer compensation, donors, and so forth can make a very strong positive impression. Increased trust can also be achieved by engaging in various activities that are known to enhance perceived trustworthiness and increase donations, such as participation in nonprofit ranking and rating schemes (Sloan, 2009), certification, and reporting systems, which are known self-regulatory instruments (Limor, 2005). Since these systems are normally relatively visible, self-regulatory measures should also increase the organization's familiarity among its constituencies. However, to increase familiarity there is no other recourse than extensive marketing and advertising activity, tailored to each organization's specific constituencies. Our findings indicate that improved communication with current and potential donors (as suggested also by Torres-Moraga et al., 2010), highlighting effectiveness, impact on beneficiaries and financial efficiency, may be a good way to increase donations. Thus, fundraising materials should incorporate information on the reach, outcomes, financial efficiency, and capacity of the organization. They should also highlight the voluntary accountability measures that the organizations undertook and the outcomes of any certifying or ranking agency that examined the organization.

In sum, while "the ask" is indeed a powerful influence on donations, the brand image of nonprofit organizations is imperative in soliciting donations. Organizations will be well advised to invest in their brand image and to use it wisely to improve their fundraising outcomes.

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